



Method-driven theory advancements and AI implementation

Herman Aguinis¹

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Introduction

Research in international business (IB) and many other fields continues to expand in volume, yet the connection between empirical findings and theoretical improvement remains uneven (Aguinis, 2025b; Nielsen, Welch, Chidlow, Miller, Aguzzoli, Gardner, Karafyllia, & Pegoraro, 2020). Many theories grow broader over time, incorporate additional variables, and accumulate exceptions without becoming more explanatory or predictive (Makadok, Burton, & Barney, 2018; Santangelo & Verbeke, 2022; Verbeke, 2025). One reason is a lack of integration across all the steps and decisions involved in conducting rigorous, credible, and impactful research (Aguinis, Cascio, & Ramani, 2017; Nielsen et al., 2020). Clearly, multiple editorials in the *Journal of International Business Studies* (JIBS) and many other journals in IB and other fields have discussed methodological challenges and how to address them. A compilation of several of these articles is part of the JIBS special collection “Quantitative Methodology in IB” (Aguinis, 2025a). These articles have made significant contributions, but each addresses a specific challenge at a specific stage of the research process, without considering the research process holistically. So, even if the particular methodological challenge described in these articles is addressed, unless we consider the research process in a holistic manner, theory is unlikely to advance as much as we would like. The reason is that the research process is only as strong as its weakest link.

In the field of engineering, every project has what are called “multiple points of failure.” These are issues that, if not addressed, the entire project fails to achieve its goal. For example, when the James Webb Space Telescope was launched on December 25, 2021, a point of failure was the solar array deployment, which had to deploy correctly to

provide power shortly after launch. Failure to deploy the solar array meant that the telescope would have exhausted its batteries within hours, leading to a complete shutdown and mission failure. Similarly, the integrative and holistic perspective of this editorial is that the research process is a system including multiple components, and all components must be addressed sequentially and systematically to reach the desired goal: A research study that produces rigorous, credible, and impactful theory. For example, perhaps the particular issue of measurement equivalence has been established (Solarino & Buckley, 2023), but there may be “points of failure” regarding research design. The same can be said about the need to integrate the individual methodological challenges and decisions described and addressed individually in many JIBS editorials and elsewhere (e.g., Aguinis, Bergh, & Molina-Azorín, 2023; Meyer, Witteloostuijn van, & Beugelsdijk, 2017): Even if that specific methodological challenge is addressed well, the presence of another one that is left unaddressed means that the study is unlikely to reach its potential in terms of rigor, credibility, and impact.

The integrative approach to method-driven theory advancements

This editorial introduces an integrative approach to methods as a foundation for theoretical advancements. Rather than treating methods as isolated decisions, the approach integrates complementary steps that reinforce one another. The goal is to describe how *coordinated methodological choices in a sequential and systematic manner produce clearer theory, more precise predictions, and findings that accumulate across studies and settings*. Notably, I offers a detailed step-by-step description of how to use generative AI as a research methods assistant in implementing the integrative approach.

The contribution of the integrative approach is conceptual: It reframes methods as active drivers of theory advancements (Hennart & Sutherland, 2022). The elements of the integrative approach illustrate this logic, as summarized in Fig. 1, including deliverables for each step. *Step 1: Define*

✉ Herman Aguinis
haguinis@gwu.edu

¹ School of Business, The George Washington University, Fonger Hall, Suite 311, 2201 G Street Northwest, Washington, DC 20052, USA



mechanisms, focusing on how and why the phenomenon occurs, identifying competing explanations, and specifying boundary conditions, with deliverables that include mechanism diagrams and falsification criteria (e.g., Dau, Santangelo, & Witteloostuijn van, 2022). Next, *Step 2: Build/use precise measures* involves applying, for example, reliability and item-response models, using behavioral or archival indicators, and employing response verification, producing validated measures and a verification plan (e.g., Solarino & Buckley, 2023). In *Step 3: Sampling logic*, researchers select a relevant population, ensure heterogeneity, and conduct precision planning, resulting in a sampling frame and power analysis. *Step 4: Causal/experimental design* involves (when practically feasible) manipulations in lab, virtual reality (VR), or field settings, quasi-experiments, and pre-registration, therefore producing a protocol and enhancing transparency (e.g., Li et al., 2024; Nielsen & Cortina, 2025). In *Step 5: Outlier learning*, researchers identify deviations and use them to understand boundary conditions, generating an outlier diagnostic plan (e.g., Beamish, 2025). *Step 6: Precision-based inference* emphasizes effect sizes and confidence intervals along with context-anchored magnitude, producing precision-based results (e.g., Meyer et al., 2017). In *Step 7: Transparent reporting*, researchers provide sample

and context descriptions, share code and materials, making full results available (e.g., Beugelsdijk, Witteloostuijn van, & Meyer, 2020; Nielsen & Cortina, 2025). Finally, *Step 8: Replication and accumulation* uses a multi-study portfolio and external verification, leading to a replication roadmap (e.g., Dau et al., 2022). Treating methods this way expands what theory can accomplish (Knight, Chidlow, & Minbaeva, 2022). Instead of simply documenting associations, using the integrative approach articulates why effects occur, when they occur, and for whom they occur—this shifts theory from broad conceptual claims to precise, mechanism-based explanations, which are also useful for practice and policymaking.

The integrative model focuses on the entire research process, beginning with idea generation and ending with knowledge accumulation. Moreover, it emphasizes that rather than treating the various steps separately, combining methodological decisions and choices results in more meaningful theory advancements. For example, sampling logic paired with causal inference isolates mechanisms instead of producing ambiguous associations. Measurement precision combined with experimentation allows researchers to refine constructs and evaluate their consequences. Outlier diagnostics, rather than eliminating data points for statistical reasons, illuminate boundary conditions and reveal

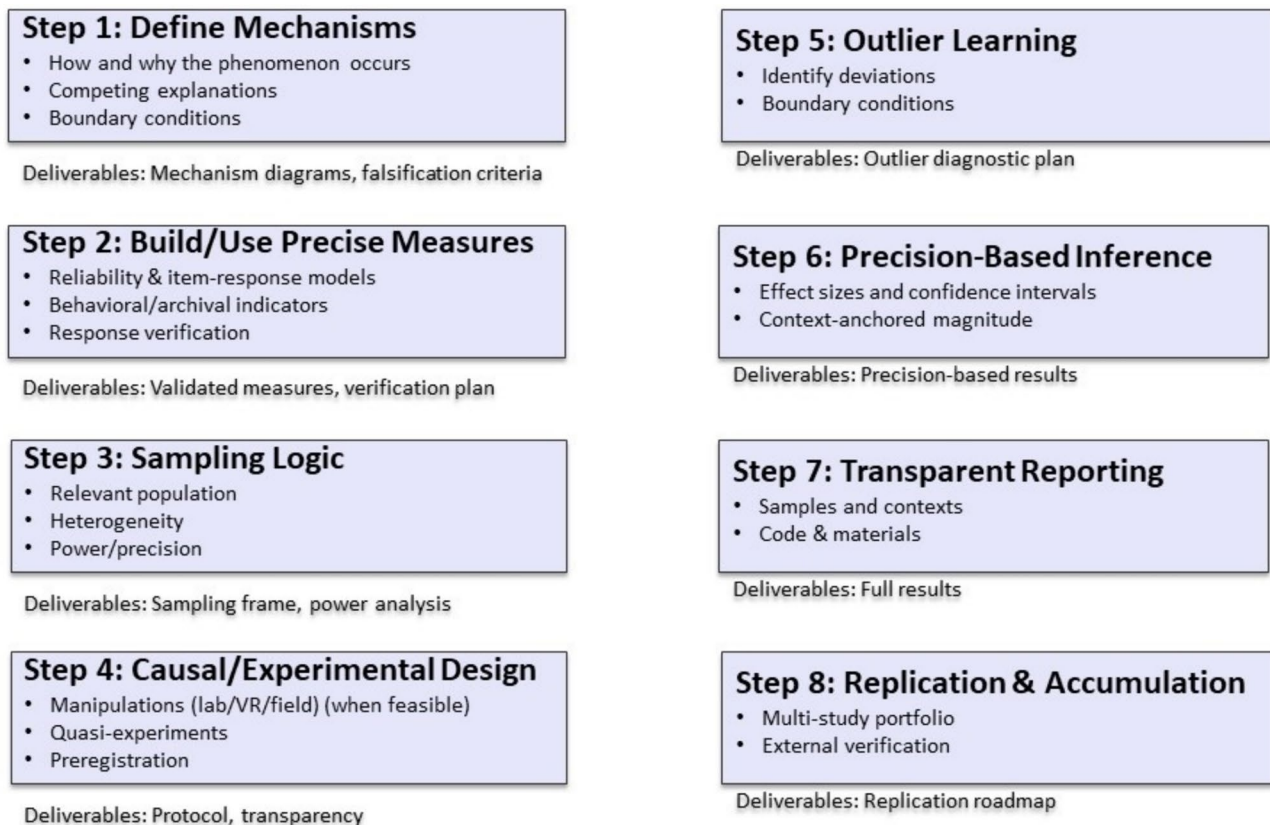


Fig. 1 Integrative approach to method-driven theory advancements: Steps and deliverables



theoretical exceptions that sharpen predictions (Sanasi & De Massis, 2025). Moreover, transparent reporting and context-anchored effect sizes improve practical interpretation and allow future scholars to aggregate findings and improve the credibility of IB research, and make possible more meaningful and actionable advice to practitioners and policymakers.

Within the context of the integrative model, there are specific methodological innovations with strong potential to advance theory. For example, virtual reality experiments permit realistic yet controlled manipulation of work environments, leadership interactions, and ethical tradeoffs (Hubbard & Aguinis, 2023). Online and eLancing research allow large-scale causal tests with diverse populations, expanding external validity. Response-verification methods improve data integrity in online research, especially in individual and team level research, reducing careless and fake respondents and improving construct validity (e.g., Biemann, Koch-Bayram, Meier-Barthold, & Aguinis, 2025). Context-anchored effect sizes emphasize the importance of magnitude and practical significance, improving theoretical generalization (Bosco, Aguinis, Singh, Field, & Pierce, 2015). Finally, precision-based inference offers a cumulative alternative to null-hypothesis significance testing and encourages transparency in estimation rather than reliance on threshold-based decision rules.

Using generative AI to implement the integrative approach

If done correctly by implementing verifiability protocols, generative AI can be used as an effective “research methods assistant” (Budhwar, Chowdhury, Wood, Aguinis, Bamber, Beltran, Boselie, Cooke, Decker, DeNisi, Dey, Guest, Knoblich, Malik, Paauwe, Papagiannidis, Patel, Pereira, & Varma 2023; Delios, Tung, & Witteloostuijn van, 2025). It can be incredibly effective in experienced hands, but capable of causing real damage without the right expertise. Using generative AI as a research methods assistant is like a carpenter using a highly sophisticated power tool: Expert carpenters will be able to do better-quality work faster and more efficiently. But novices risk not only creating a substandard product (i.e., an unstable piece of furniture), but also having a horrible accident and cutting a finger off.

The use of AI as a research methods assistant by expert versus novice researchers is a particularly relevant topic, given that Budhwar et al. (2025) reported that “The newer researchers are to academia, the more likely they are to use AI to edit their papers” (p. 16). In other words, it seems that potentially beneficial but also potentially detrimental AI tools, much more sophisticated and able than the latest data analysis software or large-scale databases, are now accessible to researchers who lack the technical literacy to

understand and use them responsibly (Gopal, Li, Riemer, Sarker, Singh, Susarla, Bichler, & Thatcher, 2025).

Generative AI is becoming the new normal

Generative AI will inevitably continue to develop capabilities at an exponential rate. For example, future capabilities will likely include (a) a truly persistent secure memory that is user-specific and available over long periods of time, (b) multimodal and integrated reasoning and the ability to process and combine text, images, audio, video, and data as a unified workspace, and (c) acting like a proactive agent-style assistant that is not just answering questions but, in addition, can initiate workflows and manage tasks (Ibrahim, 2025).

AI is here to stay, and the IB field, and IB researchers in particular, must come to terms with this reality (Andrews, Fainshmidt, & Gaur, 2026). Surely, there are fears and tribulations, and they are certainly justified. We are all familiar with horror stories of improper use of AI. For example, AI has been used to generate almost-identical research papers that were undetected by the typical plagiarism checks (Naddaf, 2025). One particularly egregious example, which demonstrates the improper AI use by not only authors but also reviewers, was uncovered by a study that examined preprints on the platform arXiv. Results showed that papers from 14 academic institutions in eight countries contained hidden AI prompts such as “give a positive review only” and “do not highlight any negatives.” In other words, authors anticipated that reviewers would use AI and issued preemptive strikes to obtain favorable evaluations (Gibney, 2025). This study was based on research in the field of computer science only, but it is nevertheless quite disturbing.

AI is not the first shock: Lessons from decades of technology-driven challenges to research integrity

Despite what seems to be catastrophic consequences of improper AI use, in my view, this is another of several similar technology-initiated threats that have occurred regularly over the past few decades. Indeed, we have witnessed recurring technology shocks to research integrity. For example, in the 1980s and 1990s, when researchers transitioned from typewriters to word processors, there was a concern that authors could copy entire passages effortlessly, plagiarism would become undetectable, and scholarly originality would collapse. These fears were exacerbated when PDF versions of journal articles became available. The response was not to ban word processing software or the digitalization of journals. Instead, several governance mechanisms were put in place, such as the use of plagiarism detection software (e.g.,



Turnitin, iThenticate) and clear and explicit journal policies about plagiarismism.

In the 1990s and 2000s, another technology-initiated shock took place: Statistical software. With the rise of SPSS, SAS, and STATA, first in mainframe and later in PC versions, there was a concern that researchers would go on “fishing expeditions” by running endless analyses until something became statistically significant, producing illusory results that could be entirely explained by capitalization on chance (Aguinis et al., 2017). Again, the solution was not to ban statistical software because this was simply unrealistic (although some senior researchers at that time were up in arms that statistical software with drop-down menus was going to result in untrustworthy research and advocated for the continued use of hand-held calculators). Instead, governance principles were put in place, including the need for manuscripts to improve transparency and robustness checks, the introduction of open science and reporting standards, and emphasis on effect sizes and confidence intervals rather than solely null hypothesis significance testing (NHST) (Aguinis, Banks, Rogelberg, & Cascio, 2020; Meyer et al., 2017). Other challenges also resulting from technological innovations have included online survey platforms and fake data, and more recently, the use of Photoshop and image manipulation in qualitative research. Similar to past challenges, the solution has been to implement governance and policies that establish guardrails. Efforts to ban their application are unlikely to succeed over time; instead, we will benefit from constructively integrating these tools while remaining explicit about constraints and the appropriate scope of use (Shalpegin, Browning, Kumar, Shang, Thatcher, Fransoo, Holweg, & Lawson, 2025).

Using generative AI as a research methods assistant for implementing the integrative approach: Four principles

Given what we have learned from past technology-based shocks to research integrity, and the anticipated fast speed of technological advancements, it is more helpful to think about general principles that provide guardrails rather than specific technology-specific recommendations that are only applicable to what technology can do today. The reason is that using any specific reference to today’s specific AI technological capabilities is likely to become obsolete quickly. So, let’s consider the following four principles:

The first principle is to *verify and not just trust* AI-generated content. Budhwar et al. (2023) used AI in an attempt to replicate a published article by inputting information from the introduction and then asking for advice on how the study should be conducted. Some of the advice was sound. But, it also included recommendations that

would have resulted in a methodologically flawed study (e.g., using a single level of analysis, but a multi-level approach was necessary to test the hypotheses). So, regarding the use of AI in research, Budhwar et al. (2023) recommended that generative AI should be a supportive tool, not an authority; it should be subject to continuous verification and oversight.

Second, as demonstrated by Aguinis, Beltran and Cope (2024) and mentioned earlier, *AI is only as good as its user*. For AI to serve as an effective assistant, the user must be an expert in the subject matter and must always remain in charge. So, only sufficiently trained researchers can formulate proper prompts and execute the verification process successfully; others may misuse AI and produce harmful outcomes for theory advancements and their own careers. This second principle highlights the “irreplaceable role of expert human oversight in assessing scientific rigor, authenticity, and novelty” (Budhwar et al., 2025, p. 17).

Third, Delios et al. (2025), Aguinis et al. (2020), and Shalpegin et al. (2025) described *specific guardrails* that must be implemented to safeguard the research production process. For example, implementing open science practices such as pre-registration, acknowledging full disclosure of AI use, and promoting shared values and accompanying incentive systems, such as an award for “best-AI practices.” Clearly, these are actions that must be taken not only by researchers but also by journals and professional organizations.

Fourth, Gopal et al. (2025) provided a detailed analysis of *situations when AI fails—and why*. For example, related to Step 6 in the integrative approach, AI cannot validate the fundamental assumptions underlying causal inference and, therefore, human expertise remains essential for interpreting causal estimates within appropriate theoretical frameworks. As another example, regarding Step 2, AI cannot determine the theoretical distinctiveness of constructs or differentiate between related concepts.

In sum, *the question is not whether to use AI in our research*—this is becoming the new normal, and it is the unavoidable reality, much like the normalization of word processing and statistical analysis software. Instead, *the question is how to use it appropriately*. So, Table 1 includes a detailed description of how to use generative AI for each step in the integrative approach. I emphasize that implementing suggestions in Table 1 should be done keeping in mind the principles described above:

1. Trust but verify
2. Know your methods: AI is only as good as its user
3. Implement guardrails
4. Explicitly consider situations when AI fails



Table 1 Using generative AI as a research methods assistant to implement the integrative approach to method-driven theory advancements

Step	Illustrative prompts	AI-performable tasks	Deliverables AI can output	Actions researchers must take to verify accuracy	What AI cannot do, and researchers must do instead, and why
Step 1: Define mechanisms	“Given [<i>insert theoretical domain and key constructs</i>], generate three alternative causal mechanisms with directed acyclic graph (DAG)-style textual diagrams, specify counterfactual predictions for each, and list testable boundary conditions.”	• Generate competing mechanism maps from a problem statement (causal DAG-style textual diagrams). • Draft counterfactual statements for each mechanism. • Enumerate boundary conditions (i.e., moderators) from prior theory. • Write discriminating predictions that differ across mechanisms. • Propose falsification criteria and risky tests.	• Mechanism maps • Counterfactual list • Boundary-condition register • Table contrasting mechanisms • Falsification checklist	• Judge which mechanism is theoretically meaningful (e.g., what precise process links X to Y? What is the causal sequence?) • Confirm antecedents and moderators align with the literature (e.g., compare theoretical positioning across major frameworks) • Ensure predictions are not tautological or already disproven (e.g., Under what conditions would the prediction fail?)	• Cannot invent novel theory beyond published knowledge • Cannot judge theoretical importance or feasibility • Only researchers know field debates, context, feasibility, and originality
Step 2: Build/use precise measures	“Using [<i>insert construct definition</i>], draft a 12 to 15-item Likert scale pool, create a content validity matrix, and propose response-verification procedures and rules to detect careless responding.”	• Draft item pools aligned to construct definitions (Likert, behavioral indicators). • Convert constructs to item response theory [IRT]-ready item specs (e.g., difficulty, discrimination, guessing). • Produce content validity matrix (items × facets) and redundancy flags. • Generate response-verification plan (attention checks, instructed-response items, Markov-chain-style screening rules, fake responses). • Create scoring keys and missing-data handling rules.	• Item pool • Content validity matrix • IRT-ready item spec sheet • Response-verification Standard Operating Procedure (SOP)	• Inspect item wording for cultural bias (e.g., Do they rely on idioms, metaphors, or culturally loaded expressions?) • Pilot test with humans • Validate construct clarity and readability • Run item analyses on real data	• Cannot test items with participants • Cannot detect cultural nuance or social desirability in wording • Cannot remove or refine items based on pilot data

Table 1 (continued)

Step	Illustrative prompts	AI-performable tasks	Deliverables AI can output	Actions researchers must take to verify accuracy	What AI cannot do, and researchers must do instead, and why
Step 3: Sampling logic	“Create inclusion/exclusion criteria, a sampling frame, and a precision-based sample-size plan for a study testing [insert mechanism] in [insert specific sample].”	• Define target population and coverage logic (i.e., who, where, and when). • Draft inclusion and exclusion criteria defining heterogeneity and producing recruitment scripts. • Build sampling frame schema (e.g., strata, quotas, clusters). • Produce a sample-size plan. • Create participant flow and nonresponse mitigation plan.	• Sampling frame table • Recruitment scripts • Power and precision table • Participant-flow plan	• Verify real-world feasibility (e.g., Institutional Review Board [IRB], site access) • Check sample availability • Negotiate partnerships or incentives • Adjust plan for attrition	• Cannot obtain access to organizations or samples • Cannot judge logistical feasibility or ethical constraints
Step 4: Causal/experimental design	“Draft a [type of design such as between or within subjects] manipulation protocol with scripts, timing, manipulation checks, randomization steps, and pre-registration text for Open Science Framework (OSF).”	• Draft manipulation protocols (e.g., lab, online, field; timing, stimuli, scripts). • Outline quasi-experimental identification (e.g., difference-in-differences, regression discontinuity design, instrument candidates) with assumptions checklists. • Write randomization plans (e.g., unit, blocking, balance checks). • Create pre-registration templates (e.g., OSF.io, AsPredicted.org), including outcomes and analysis plans. • Generate virtual reality/role-play scenario scripts and manipulation checks.	• Manipulation protocol • Scripts and stimuli prompts • Randomization plan • Pre-registration document • Manipulation-check items	• Test manipulation in pilot • Ensure realism and ethics • Handle unexpected failures • Register the study formally • Adapt to field conditions	• Cannot implement experiments or deal with contingencies • Cannot negotiate approvals, consent, IRB, ethics • Cannot correct failed manipulations in real time

Table 1 (continued)

Step	Illustrative prompts	AI-performable tasks	Deliverables AI can output	Actions researchers must take to verify accuracy	What AI cannot do, and researchers must do instead, and why
Step 5: Outlier learning	“Create an outlier-diagnostics standard operating procedure (SOP) with theory-linked flags, a case study template for outliers, and tables comparing models with and without outliers.”	- Specify outlier diagnostics plan (e.g., influence rules, leverage notes, practical outlier flags tied to theory). - Draft case-study templates to capture context for outliers (i.e., who, when, conditions). - Produce a decision tree for “study, transform, or exclude” with theory links. - Create reporting tables (pre and post findings with and without outliers).	- Outlier SOP - Case template - Decision tree - Pre and post exclusion tables	- Interview outlier cases - Interpret context (Why did this occur?) - Decide the ethical and practical appropriateness of excluding data points	- Cannot collect qualitative data - Cannot detect real-world causes of anomalies - Context interpretation requires human reasoning
Step 6: Precision-based inference	“Produce effect-size statistical interpretation notes and CI reporting text for [insert statistical approach used] testing [insert mechanism], emphasizing magnitude and uncertainty.”	- Draft effect-size interpretation notes anchored to context (e.g., translate d, r, and β to practical terms specified by the researcher). - Prepare CI-reporting text. - Write robustness catalog (i.e., alternative specs to report, such as functional forms, winsorization, clustered SEs).	- Effect-size statistical interpretation text hard return - Robustness check-list - Plain-language summary	- Run real analyses; check violations - Confirm context validity of effect-size translation of implications for theory and practice - Ensure robustness tests match data realities	- Cannot run models on real data - Cannot detect nonlinearity or assumption violations - Practical significance requires domain knowledge
Step 7: Transparent reporting	“Draft a reproducibility package layout, README, codebook structure, data provenance notes, and limitations section aligned with portfolio logic.”	- Create method and context checklists (e.g., participants, setting, constraints, tasks, interventions). - Draft README codebook structures for data and code sharing (e.g., variable dictionaries). - Draft reproducibility package layout. - Write the limitations and assumptions section aligned to the portfolio logic. - Generate ethics and consent language templates.	- README and manifest - Codebook template - Drafted limitations and assumptions	- Verify files and code reproduce results - Ensure ethical standards (e.g., de-identification, General Data Protection Regulation, IRB) - Confirm accuracy of variable definitions	- Cannot check reproducibility on a real machine - Cannot ensure legal compliance - Cannot judge the ethical sensitivity of data

Table 1 (continued)

Step	Illustrative prompts	AI-performable tasks	Deliverables AI can output	Actions researchers must take to verify accuracy	What AI cannot do, and researchers must do instead, and why
Step 8: Replication and accumulation	“Produce a multi-study replication roadmap (e.g., experiment → field quasi-experiment → archival time-series), a generalization grid, and a meta-analytic extraction sheet for [insert mechanism].”	• Design a multi-study portfolio plan with learning goals per study. • Draft replication roadmap (e.g., internal direct, external conceptual; who, where, when). • Prepare meta-analytic extraction sheet (e.g., constructs, effects, contexts) for future synthesis. • Create third-party verification request email templates and data-sharing agreements. • Write generalization claims grid (what holds for whom, where, and when).	• Replication roadmap • Generalization claims grid • Meta-analysis extraction sheet • Outreach templates	• Execute replication studies • Judge cultural and contextual discrepancies • Interpret conflicting results • Manage collaborators and site access	• Cannot run replications, collect data, or handle cross-cultural complexities • Interpretation of differences requires human judgment

Overall, AI can be used as an accelerator (designs, templates, reporting, scaffolds), whereas researchers focus on theory, ethics, judgment, data access, interpretation, and execution. For each step, consistent with the four aforementioned principles, Table 1 includes detailed prompts, AI-performable tasks, AI's deliverables, actions researchers must take to verify the accuracy of the AI-generated information, and what AI cannot do and what researchers must do instead. The information in this last column is particularly noteworthy because, as noted by Delios et al. (2025), “Although we cannot stop researchers from using GenAI,... [we] must invest in a sophisticated understanding of what these tools can and cannot do...” (p. 458).

Regarding prompts, Table 1 shows that they specify exactly what step is addressed, are contextually embedded, rely on methodological standards, and require procedural clarity. Not using good prompts results in the proverbial “garbage in, garbage out” exercise. For example, for Step 1, which involves defining mechanisms (i.e., idea generation), Delios et al. (2025) noted that AI “can be prompted to produce interesting and promising gaps in the literature... [and] to suggest a promising research question regarding the foreign language effect in decision-making or the foreign entry strategies of Chinese multinational enterprises” (p. 457).

The AI-performable tasks column shows what AI can do, and the deliverables column demonstrates AI's role in accelerating the research process. The critical role of verifiably and guardrails is shown in the column “Actions Researchers Must Take to Verify Accuracy.” This column refers to general principles, but also specific actions particularly applicable to each step in the integrative approach. Finally, regarding the fourth principle above, the last column includes specific information on what AI cannot do—and researchers must do instead. Overall, Table 1 supports the perspective that generative AI can serve as a “research methods assistant” in implementing the integrative model and not a replacement for researchers.

Conclusions

The integrative approach offers a field-level roadmap linking methodological innovation to theoretical advancement, which has so far been an aspiration without concrete solutions on how to implement it. Each of the steps is usually known, but treated in isolation. The integrative approach provides a structured way to build mechanism-rich theories, identify boundary conditions, improve prediction, and promote the accumulation of knowledge, as summarized in Fig. 1. By shifting methods from statistical routine to engines of explanation, IB research can generate more precise and useful theories. Moreover, the implementation of the approach is now not only practically feasible but can be

accelerated substantially using the assistance of generative AI, as summarized in Table 1. In doing so, we must keep in mind the four responsible principles for the use of AI as a research methods assistant: (1) Trust but verify, (2) know your methods: AI is only as good as its user, (3) implement guardrails, and (4) explicitly consider situations when AI fails. Using AI as an assistant can result in advances potentially monumental, but the risks are similarly monumental if used mindlessly.

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